

WC2026 Friends Pool - Rules

Everyone drafts teams from three odds-tiered pots. Your teams earn (and lose) points across the whole tournament from the categories below. Most points at the end wins. The pool leans into chaos - plenty of ways to score are deliberately perverse, so read carefully.

Goals & shots

Event	Points
Open-play goal	+0.5 each
Free-kick goal	doubles the OPPONENT team's points for that game (scores nothing for you)
Penalty scored - not a shootout	-1.5 each
Penalty scored - in a shootout	-0.5 each
Goal ruled out by VAR	-1 each
0 shots on target in a game	+4
Goal scored OR conceded in the 23rd or 67th minute	+4 (max +4 per game, even if you own both teams)
Each game your team fails to score (clean sheet against you)	-1 (own both teams & it's 0-0 = 0; extra time excluded)
Prime number of total goals in the tournament (excludes shootout goals)	-3

A free-kick goal still counts toward your team's total-goals tally (so it can still trigger the prime -3 and the fewest-goals award) - it just earns you nothing directly.

The 90'+ rule

- A goal from 90:00 onwards - the 90th minute and ALL of its injury/stoppage time (recorded as 90 or 90+X) - multiplies that team's IN-GAME points for that game by -1 - i.e. the goals, the 23'/67' bonus, the 0-shots-on-target bonus, the clean-sheet, and the red-card dice from that game.
- 90:00 ONWARDS, INJURY TIME ONLY - this is NOT extra time. A goal in extra time (91-120, e.g. 105 or 120) does NOT count for this rule.
- It hits ONLY that game's in-game total. It does NOT touch the tournament-long ranked prizes (quickest goal, quickest yellow, fastest sub, fastest own goal, youngest/oldest scorer, longest/shortest name, fewest goals, fewest cards) or the prime-goals penalty - those are never flipped.
- Two 90'+ goals in the same game cancel out ($\times -1 \times -1 =$ back to positive).
- In-game points flip in ANY game (win or lose).
- Progression points only flip in your ELIMINATION game. Winning teams bank no progression at that moment, so a champion's Winner points are always safe - but a runner-up who scores a 90'+ goal in the final they lose flips their +8 to -8.

Red card - roll the dice

- When one of your teams gets a red card, roll a single d6.
- Odd roll -> you GAIN (roll / 2) points: 1 = +0.5, 3 = +1.5, 5 = +2.5
- Even roll -> you LOSE (roll / 2) points: 2 = -1, 4 = -2, 6 = -3
- No rounding - half-points stand.

Ranked categories

Each category ranks the top 6 teams across the whole tournament. Positive categories pay 10 / 8 / 5 / 3 / 2 / 1; penalty categories pay the negative of that.

Direction	Points (top 6)	Categories
Reward	10 / 8 / 5 / 3 / 2 / 1	Quickest Goal · Youngest Goalscorer · Fastest Substitute · Fastest Own Goal · Quickest Yellow Card · Longest-Named Goalscorer
Penalty	-10 / -8 / -5 / -3 / -2 / -1	Oldest Goalscorer · Shortest-Named Goalscorer

- An owner can only win a given category once - if you own both the best and second-best team in it, the second prize rolls down to the next DISTINCT owner.
- Ties split the points between the tied owners (owning several tied teams = a bigger share).
- Tiebreak: the most recent occurrence ranks higher.
- Data source priority: official FIFA, else BBC, else ITV.

Flat awards

- Fewest Goals (whole tournament): +7 to the single team with fewest (tie-split between owners).
- Fewest Cards (whole tournament): +7 to the single team with fewest (tie-split between owners).

Tournament progression

Points for the furthest stage a team reaches, realised in the game they're eliminated.

R32	R16	QF	SF	Runner-up	Winner
+1	+2	+3	+5	+8	+10

- 3rd-place playoff WINNER: -5 (cancels their SF +5, so 3rd place nets 0).
- 4th place (loses the 3rd-place playoff): keeps the SF +5.

The draft - pots

16 players. Each player drafts THREE teams - one from each pot - so every squad gets a strong team, a mid team and a long shot (16 players x 3 = the full 48). The pots are seeded by each team's "to reach the quarter-finals" odds: Pot 1 is the 16 strongest, Pot 3 the 16 longest shots.

Pot 1 - strongest	Pot 2 - middle	Pot 3 - long shots
Spain	Japan	Australia
France	Uruguay	Ghana
England	Croatia	South Africa
Portugal	Ecuador	Panama
Argentina	Senegal	DR Congo
Brazil	Austria	Saudi Arabia
Germany	Ivory Coast	Tunisia
Netherlands	Canada	Uzbekistan
Norway	Sweden	New Zealand
Belgium	Paraguay	Cape Verde
Colombia	Scotland	Jordan
Morocco	South Korea	Iraq

Pot 1 - strongest	Pot 2 - middle	Pot 3 - long shots
Mexico	Egypt	Haiti
USA	Algeria	Qatar
Switzerland	Czechia	Curaçao
Turkey	Bosnia & Herzegovina	Iran

Prizes & forfeits

- 1st place: a shirt of any sports team of their choice, paid for by everyone else (capped at £150).
- Last place: must buy SEVEN other players (their choice) dessert - in person, and within 3 months of the final.
- The dice gift: once the final standings are locked, roll a 16-sided die twice. The player who finished in the FIRST position rolled buys the player who finished in the SECOND a £20 gift. Re-roll if the same position comes up twice.

Rules locked from the conversation of June 2026. If anything here doesn't match what you expected, flag it before the draft.